Structural Comparison of the Five-Stage Model and Prior Theories

Do Different Labels Point to the Same Thing?

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Structural Comparison of the Five-Stage Model and Prior Theories

1. Framing the Question



Figure 1: The 5-Stage Model — Structural Comparison with Prior Research

Creativity research, cognitive science, organizational theory, psychoanalysis, complexity science — these domains have used different labels and described creative processes at different scales. Wallas's four stages, Guilford's divergent/convergent thinking, Bion's negative capability, Prigogine's dissipative structures, Nonaka's SECI model. Are these describing different things, or are they pointing to different facets of the same structure?

This paper presents the five-stage model (Field → Wave → Relation → Vortex → Bundle) as an analytical framework, and reports the results of an investigation spanning 30 academic domains. The analysis has three objectives:

1. To examine whether prior theories and the five-stage model point to the same structure
2. To identify what is not expressed by existing labels — structures that prior theories may have overlooked
3. To examine what the five-stage model itself may have overlooked

This is an exercise in what we term "finger-pointing-at-the-moon" description. The five-stage model and prior theories are each fingers pointing at the moon. The goal is not to judge which finger is better, but to analyze whether they point at the same moon.

2. Method

2.1 Study Design

Thirty academic domains were selected, with ten theories or concepts chosen from each domain. Selection criteria were: inclusion of stage-based or structural descriptions of creative processes, and established influence within the domain.

2.2 Evaluation Method

For each theory, structural correspondence with the five-stage model was evaluated across eight dimensions (E-1 through E-8). Evaluations were structured using four-facet description:

Facet	Content
Similarity	Elements believed to point to the same structure as the five-stage model
Uniqueness	Structures present in one but absent in the other
Learning	Insights from prior theories that should be incorporated
Context	The original context of each theory, not translated into this model's terminology

Quality checks included non-duality checks (preventing facile identification), fractal checks (preventing scale conflation), and blind-men-and-elephant checks (confirmation across three or more domains).

2.3 Methodological Limitations

This analysis has the following limitations. First, evaluators were AI systems (multiple models providing multi-perspective evaluation) and the author; expert review within each domain has not been conducted. Second, correspondence judgments are qualitative, and no statistical verification has been performed. Third, the selection of 30 domains itself may contain author bias.

These limitations indicate that this analysis is at the hypothesis-generation phase. Hypothesis testing is a task for the future and falls outside the scope of this paper.

3. Definition of the Five-Stage Model

The five-stage model describes creation not as "the ability to produce good ideas" but as a continuous transformation from one state to another.

Stage	Name	Structure	Process	What Is Generated
1	Field	Zero / Void	Stillness	Matrix of possibility
2	Wave	Oscillation / Opposition	Separation	Differences, directions
3	Relation	Boundary / Relationship	Connection	Rules, constraints, links
4	Vortex	Individuation / Emergence	Integration	Coherence (prototype)
5	Bundle	Direction	Aggregation	Structured outcome

The five stages are cyclical, not linear. The return from Bundle to Field — taking the generated structure as a given and letting the next unease drift — sustains creation.

A note on scope: while the five-stage model — articulated by the author from lived experience — is presented here as a model of "the creative process," the investigation found structural correspondences with broader phenomena including self-organization, individuation, and phase transitions. The distinction between physical, biological, and psychological individuation may be no more than labels on a spectrum. This breadth of scope is examined further in §6.

The connection to Kesson-Driven Thinking is as follows. Field is a state of zero, of void. Not even unease has arisen. The first faint stirring marks the beginning of the transition to Wave. Containment — the function of not processing reflexively but holding errors as questions — operates from Wave onward. At Wave, Survival-Trust evaluation (survival axis / attachment axis) gives rise to opposition. At Relation, multiple evaluations intersect. At Vortex, a new structure emerges as errors are reintegrated. At Bundle, reusable knowledge stabilizes.

4. Structural Comparison with Prior Research

4.1 Wallas's Four-Stage Model

Wallas's preparation → incubation → illumination → verification remains the most influential stage model in creativity research.

Facet	Analysis
Similarity	Incubation corresponds to Field–Wave, illumination to Relation–Vortex, and verification to Bundle. The basic structure of alternation between conscious work and unconscious processing is shared
Uniqueness	The five-stage model includes "Relation" as an explicit stage. In Wallas's description, the transition between incubation and illumination — the state where contradiction peaks and refuses to converge — is not structurally described
Learning	The importance of Wallas's "preparation" stage. The five-stage model's "Field" subsumes preparation, but the process of intentional knowledge acquisition remains implicit
Context	Wallas's model is based on introspective reports and primarily describes individual thought processes. Social processes are outside its scope

Whether Wallas's description contains an explicit stage corresponding to Relation: structural similarity is observable in late incubation, but it is not described as an independent stage.

4.2 Guilford's Divergent/Convergent Thinking

Facet	Analysis
Similarity	Divergence corresponds to the first half of Field–Wave–Relation; convergence corresponds to Vortex–Bundle. The basic distinction of thinking direction is shared
Uniqueness	The dichotomy erases Relation. The stage where contradiction peaks — a state that is neither divergent nor convergent — has no name

Facet	Analysis
Learning	Measurement methods for divergent thinking (fluency, flexibility, originality) are useful as operational definitions of the Wave stage
Context	Guilford's model is a framework for individual-difference research based on factor analysis, not primarily intended as a stage description of process

This analysis illustrates both why the divergent/convergent dichotomy has been widely adopted (operationally definable, easily measured) and its cost (the invisibility of Relation).

4.3 SECI Model (Nonaka & Takeuchi)

Facet	Analysis
Similarity	Socialization corresponds to Field, externalization to Wave–Relation, combination to Vortex, and internalization to Bundle. The basic structure of transformation between tacit and explicit knowledge is similar
Uniqueness	SECI's "Ba" is a social context (shared space), whereas the five-stage model's "Field" is an intra-individual undifferentiated state. The nominal similarity must not be mistaken for structural identity
Learning	SECI's description as an organizational knowledge-creation process. The five-stage model originates from intra-individual process and requires connection to SECI's social dimension
Context	SECI is an organizational theory / management framework describing organizational knowledge transformation, not individual cognitive process

4.4 Flow Experience (Csikszentmihalyi)

Facet	Analysis
Similarity	The "challenge–skill balance" in flow experience is structurally similar to the holding of contradiction at the Relation stage
Uniqueness	Flow is not a stage but is more appropriately understood as a quality of progression that can occur during any transition between stages. Flow describes not "which stage you are at" but "how the transition between stages is proceeding"
Learning	Conditions for optimal experience (clear goals, immediate feedback, challenge/skill balance) are informative as conditions for smooth transitions between the five stages

Facet	Analysis
Context	Csikszentmihalyi's research is a phenomenological description of subjective experience, not a structural model

4.5 Bion's Negative Capability

Facet	Analysis
Similarity	Negative capability — the capacity to remain in a state without answers — structurally overlaps with the core of the Relation stage. The insight that remaining in uncertainty is a condition for creation is isomorphic with the discipline of Relation
Uniqueness	The five-stage model positions negative capability not as a standalone capacity but as a structural requirement at a specific stage (Relation). That is, it provides a structural answer to "why remaining is necessary"
Learning	Bion's container/contained concept is useful as an auxiliary concept describing the conditions for remaining at Relation — the quality of relationships that can hold contradiction
Context	Bion's descriptions are situated in the clinical context of psychoanalysis, and their application to individual cognitive processes requires interpretation

4.6 Complexity Science (Dissipative Structures, Self-Organization)

Facet	Analysis
Similarity	Strong structural correspondence was confirmed between the formation process of dissipative structures — systems far from equilibrium generating new order through fluctuation — and the five stages. Field corresponds to equilibrium, Wave to amplification of fluctuation, Relation to the metastable state near the critical point, Vortex to spontaneous formation of new order, and Bundle to stable structure
Uniqueness	Physical descriptions of self-organization lack a volitional element of "remaining at Relation." The five-stage model introduces Containment — a volitional function of holding — at this stage
Learning	Quantitative findings on behavior near critical points are useful as auxiliary lines for understanding the characteristics of the Relation stage

Facet	Analysis
Context	These are descriptions of physicochemical phenomena. The correspondence with human creative processes is at the stage of structural similarity. Whether this correspondence represents structural identity or superficial similarity remains an open question

5. Cross-Domain Findings

The investigation across 30 domains revealed the following cross-domain patterns.

5.1 Ubiquity of a Stage Corresponding to Relation

The most striking finding is that "a state where contradiction peaks and refuses to converge" has been independently described in many domains. Bion's negative capability, the critical point in complexity science, Turner's liminality in anthropology, van Eyck's in-between in architecture — these likely point to the same structure under different labels.

Meanwhile, existing stage models rarely describe this stage explicitly. Wallas's four stages, Guilford's divergent/convergent thinking, the Double Diamond of design thinking — none independently name a stage corresponding to Relation. This is likely because Relation is a stage that is difficult to measure and operationalize.

5.2 "Boundaries Are Thick"

Across multiple domains, findings confirmed that boundary regions in creative processes are not mere transition points but "thick" regions with their own structure. The critical region of phase transitions in complexity science, the thickness of walls in architecture (where the boundary becomes a place), the liminal phase of rites of passage in anthropology — all suggest that the boundary itself is a site of creation.

5.3 Universality of Cyclical Structure

The return from Bundle to Field — where a stable structure becomes the starting point of the next instability — is observed at different scales: feedback loops in complexity science, the knowledge spiral in SECI, and development-and-reorganization in biology. Linear stage models (Wallas) have structural difficulty describing this cycling.

6. Status of Evidence and Open Questions

6.1 What Is Confirmed

The structural definition of the five stages and the basic characterization of each stage are confirmed. The finding that structural correspondence was confirmed across the majority of the 30 domains can be reported as fact.

6.2 Promising but Under Verification

The finding that Relation has the highest discriminative power for structural similarity has been consistently confirmed across multiple domains and is considered a promising hypothesis. The pattern that "boundaries are thick" is similarly supported.

6.3 Open Questions

The following are declared as holding points.

The scale problem: There appear to be scale differences between physical critical phenomena and human creative processes. Whether this correspondence represents structural identity or superficial similarity has not been resolved in this analysis. Verifying the scope of the five-stage model — the hypothesis that it describes "creation of existence itself" — is the most important task ahead.

Operational definition of Containment: The description "holding contradiction and not processing reflexively" is not yet sufficient as an operational definition. Quantitative descriptions of the conditions under which holding is possible and the conditions under which it breaks down are needed.

Connection to the social dimension: The five-stage model originates from intra-individual process, but integration with the social dimensions described by organizational theory (SECI) and social psychology remains incomplete. The nested structure of individual "Field to Bundle" and team "Field to Bundle" remains at the level of theoretical description.

Blind spots in the five-stage model itself: Because this analysis uses the five-stage model as its framework, it has a methodological limitation in detecting structures that the five-stage model itself overlooks. This limitation is partially addressed by analyzing the "Uniqueness" facet of prior theories (what is present in prior theories but absent in the five-stage model), though this is not sufficient.

6.4 Disclosure of Temperature

The results of this analysis report that structural correspondence between prior theories across different domains and the five-stage model has been widely confirmed. Concluding that this correspondence means "they point to the same structure" requires expert verification within individual domains, introduction of quantitative analytical methods, and refinement of the operational definitions of the five-stage model itself.

Rather than hiding what is not yet confirmed, disclosing the state of evidence as it stands is the honest form of reporting for this analysis.

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